

Put the Team Before Yourself: Pat in Her Own Words

Coach Pat Summitt

Every year, at the beginning of the year when we bring our team to the court, the first thing that we talk about is getting better as a team. We don't talk about winning national championship. We talk about the details. We talk about being better ball handlers, being better shooters, being better screeners, learning how to play together.

You know, it's difficult sometimes for players to think about the team concept. But that's what it's all about. And the little things add up to the big things, to the great things. And so, as we are teaching, we're teaching all the details, and we want them to embrace.

We have a system. You know, if you've got a team, the team has to embrace the system. And here at the University of Tennessee, more times than not, the system works. Why? Because the players make it work. Why? Because they want to win. They want to find greatness together. And that's what you do in corporate America. You bring a team together. And teamwork works.

But everyone has to be on board. We're only as good as our weakest player. We won't want any weak players. We want great players, great competitors that will bring together a powerful team. It's hard to get to the top. And when you get there, it's even harder to stay there.

As you think about your team, you look around the room and you ask each and every person, "Are you committed? Are you a great teammate? Are you going to help us have the most powerful team?" We do this together. Do it and do it now.